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Designing Place: Reimagining a Peripheral Town's Narrative through Experience Design

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Abstract

This paper introduces the concept of *designing place* as a specific type of experience design by exploring its application in revitalizing a peripheral town facing economic, social, political, and demographic challenges. We illustrate how reimagining the narrative of a peripheral town can enhance the quality of life for residents, make it attractive to newcomers, and contribute to enduring urban and regional development. We argue that *designing place* extends beyond traditional urban planning and infrastructure development to incorporate a holistic approach to experience that integrates cognitive, emotional, behavioral, sensorial, and social factors. *Designing place* aims to create a sense of belonging and well-being, and thus contributes to the broader discourse on the role of design in fostering impactful transformations in a rapidly changing world. We contribute to the design literature by delineating the dimensions of *designing place* and offer practical implications for policymakers and community leaders seeking to reimagine peripheral towns.

Keywords: designing place, experience design, peripheral towns, urban development

Introduction

> *If there was a town that couldn't do anything, it was Horsens. The big, the strong, the spectacular – we left that to other towns. (Henning Nörbæk)*

In the design discourse, the concept of experience design (Pine and Gilmore, 1998; Candi et al., 2013; Beltagui et al., 2012; Homburg et al., 2017; Lemon and Verhoef, 2016) is recognized as a holistic approach that can apply to the design of products, services, or indeed, experiences. This paper responds to this Special Issue's call (Swan et al., 2023) by exploring how experience design can address contemporary economic, social, political, and demographic challenges faced by peripheral towns by reimagining their narratives. We coin the term *designing place* to represent a paradigm shift in urban or regional design, where the focus extends beyond physical artifacts, buildings, and infrastructure to encompass the holistic experience of a community. This approach integrates innovative design with social, economic, and cultural factors, aiming to create a sense of place, a concept that aligns with the Special Issue's theme of exploring how design contributes to belonging, well-being, and enduring transformations in a rapidly changing world (Swan et al., 2023).

In recent years, the term 'left behind places' has been widely used as a label for regions experiencing peripheralization through economic and social stagnation or decline as part of broader spatial inequality (Pike et al., 2023). In urban and regional studies, certain terminologies have been deployed to refer to disadvantaged geographical areas such as *deprived* localities, *lagging* regions, *less favored* regions, and—referring specifically to urban areas—*peripheral towns*. As large urban centers continue to expand, attracting talent and investment, peripheral towns face stagnation or decline due to suburbanization, loss of industry, and declining downtowns (Wuthnow, 2019). While some of the challenges may be similar to the ones faced by large cities, due to their "liability of smallness" (Mayer, 2022, p.77), peripheral towns do not have the agency or capacity to mobilize the same types of tools and resources as large cities to combat population loss and revitalize their downtown areas. Moreover, they may lack the obvious draw of larger cities in terms of jobs, tourism, and cultural offerings, and often face a graying population and prevailing loss of jobs.

This paper examines the key elements of *designing place* and what it entails in reimagining a peripheral town as an attractive place to live and visit. In doing so, it highlights the role of agents in this transformation, including local governments, community organizations, and residents. This study aims to shed light on the power of *spatial imaginaries* (Watkins, 2015) of a peripheral town across time by employing a design lens.

We conduct an in-depth case study of the peripheral town of Horsens in Denmark as an embodiment of *designing place*. The transformation of Horsens serves as a compelling case study of a peripheral town reimagining past, present, and future narratives (Wiese, 2013). The present and future narratives of Horsens were reimagined around *experience* thereby enhancing the quality of life for residents and transforming the town into an attractive destination for newcomers by offering memorable experiences. Meanwhile, Horsens past narrative was allotted the respect it deserved, and sugar-coating was staunchly avoided.

The contributions of this research are twofold. First, we propose designing place as an important case of experience design and identify its dimensions, thus contributing to the design literature. By integrating insights from regional development literature, we highlight the dynamic temporal dimension of designing place through the social construction of meaning and design. Second, we offer practical implications for town leaders and policymakers seeking to reimagine peripheral towns. We propose that designing place, a specific type of experience design, can lead to collective transformation, resonating with the Special Issue's focus on innovative design within a larger ecosystem (Swan et al., 2023).

Literature review

Regional development discourses on peripheral towns

Implicitly, a peripheral town lags behind large urban centers due to limited infrastructure, knowledge capital, innovation, and creativity. Against this center-peripheral model of regional development discourse, several authors highlight the complex spatial contexts and evolutionary processes behind the concept of periphery. Martin (2014) delves into the social significance of overlooked spaces in

urban, exurban, and rural landscapes. He focuses on mundane spaces as politicized landscapes that offer alternative readings of history and potential for future sociality, emphasizing the importance of understanding landscapes in historical terms and their role in shaping political understandings of place. Gibson (2014) discusses how creativity need not be confined to large urban centers but can also thrive in suburban, rural, and remote areas, highlighting the eclectic and vernacular nature of creativity in peripheral places.

As Mayer and Lazzeroni (2022) argue, small towns are not merely scaled-down versions of large cities. Small peripheral towns exhibit dynamics that are contingent upon their setting, location, and existing networks. Empirical studies have demonstrated how places transform themselves from the periphery by creating new narratives for new developmental trajectories. For instance, Rich (2013) examines the revitalization of Scranton, Pennsylvania, in the US. The study contrasts Richard Florida's creative class theory with Putnam's social capital theory, based on interviews with key stakeholders. It concludes that for small cities like Scranton, fostering a high quality of life with safety, good schools, and cultural amenities is more crucial than attracting big companies. The rebranding of Scranton as the "Electric City" and its association with "The Office" TV show are highlighted as strategies to improve the city's image and attract residents and investment. Another set of empirical insights is provided by Coenen (2023), who investigates artist-led social innovation processes in peripheral old industrial towns in Sweden and Norway. The study demonstrates a variety of ways by which artists can be agents of change, transforming peripheral places while taking responsibility for inclusion and participation.

Place identity and branding

In the place marketing and branding literature, the role of government and non-government organizations in promoting place-based economic development is emphasized. There has been a growing number of case studies dealing with the problems and possibilities of small, remote places in the literature (e.g., Nyseth & Viken 2009). Nevertheless, it is acknowledged that there is a lack of general and systematic knowledge on how places (e.g., cities, municipalities, and regions) with

different preconditions work to strengthen their attractiveness and competitiveness (Olsson and Berglund, 2010).

In addition to the spatial dimension, what seems to be underexplored in the existing literature is the temporal dimension of place branding. However, a sense of the history of a place is integral to understanding its character, identity, and worth (Lewicka, 2008). The interlinkages of past, present, and future are recognized under the concept of *omni-temporality* (Reynolds et al., 2024). It is argued that place branding is a relevant context to investigate omni-temporality since it pays specific attention to the importance of stakeholders as active participants within a dynamic temporal branding process, including aspects of the past such as history, heritage, memory, and legacy (Balmer and Burghausen, 2019; Reynolds et al., 2024). Through place branding, the past can be packaged into an identity through a collective experience of the present and constructing a narrative of the future. Reynolds et al. (2024) demonstrate how stakeholders build agency for their shared and contrasting understandings of the past, present, and future of their towns. It is also important to acknowledge that it takes time for a sense of place to evolve; it can lag behind the evolution of social and material realities (Raymond et al., 2017).

Experience design

Design can transcend technology and functionality, extending into the realm of experiential benefits, which are less tangible but potentially more valuable (Candi et al., 2013). Pine and Gilmore (1998) highlight the shift towards a service economy in the twentieth century as a stage in the progression of economic value, moving from commodities to goods, then to services, and finally to staging memorable experiences. In their later work Gilmore and Pine (2007) propose a fifth stage of economic value, that of transformation. It is here that we position our proposed concept of designing place—design that transforms a place's narrative, leading to transformations in people's perceptions of the place and even their self-image as residents of the place.

Drawing on Lemon and Verhoef (2016) experience design is defined as *design that aims to influence cognitive, emotional, behavioral, sensorial, and social responses*. Lemon and Verhoef emphasize a focus on the experience journey encompassing numerous touchpoints. Homburg et al. (2015) propose

a conceptual framework for customer experience management, which integrates cultural mindsets, strategic directions, and capabilities aimed at designing experiences that foster long-term loyalty.

Liu (2003) underscores the multisensory nature of experiences, and Beltagui et al. (2015) propose a multi-dimensional evaluation of experiences. Becker and Jaakkola (2020) address the fragmented nature of experience research, proposing fundamental premises for integrating various theoretical perspectives, which emphasize the dynamic interplay between stimuli and experiences across multiple touchpoints. Shin et al. (2019) analyze the role of empowerment in the co-creation of knowledge through personalized interactions in online tourist communities, highlighting the potent effects of personalized responses on engagement and co-creation behavior (Roberts et al., 2017).

The service-dominant logic advocated by Vargo and Lusch (2004) and its extension into the co-creation of experiences is supported by Spohrer and Maglio (2008), who view service providers primarily as facilitators in the creation of customer experiences. This emphasizes the importance of customer participation, a theme that resonates strongly in contemporary discussions on experience design. For example, Homburg et al. (2015) discuss the emergence of experience management as a strategic approach, where businesses increasingly recognize the necessity of integrating customer insights across all operational facets to enhance engagement and loyalty.

Case studies, such as those described by Lemke et al. (2010), Arnould and Price (1993), and Celsi et al. (1993), demonstrate success stories in experience design, primarily in hedonic sectors like luxury cruises and theme parks. However, their arguments can be extended beyond these sectors, suggesting that organizations, including municipalities, can design experiences, offering differentiation, emotional connection, loyalty, and word-of-mouth benefits (Shin et al., 2019; Zomerdijk and Voss, 2011).

Overall, the current discourse on experience design points to a complex interplay between multi-sensory engagement, personalized interaction, co-creation, and strategic management of customer journeys. These elements are critical to crafting experiences that are not only memorable but also deeply transformative.

Designing place

Based on synthesizing the insights from the literature reviewed in the preceding section, we propose that the concept of *designing place* is a special case of experience design. The concept extends beyond the creation of tangible products or services to encompass the transformation of entire environments and communities. Designing place embodies the fifth stage of economic value—transformation—as proposed by Gilmore and Pine (2007). It goes beyond staging memorable experiences to fundamentally transform a place's narrative, thereby reshaping people's perceptions and their self-identity as residents. This transformation is multi-modal in nature, as described by Liu (2003), engaging residents and visitors through a holistic sensory and emotional journey that redefines their interaction with the place.

Furthermore, co-creation, as advocated by Vargo and Lusch (2004) and Spohrer and Maglio (2008), is central to designing place. Residents are not mere consumers but active co-creators of the experience, contributing to the narrative and identity of their town. This participatory approach aligns with the experiential core of experience design, where the focus is on creating experiences within individuals and communities (Gilmore and Pine, 2007).

Methodology

Empirical context

The transformation of Horsens serves as a paradigmatic example of the *designing place* concept. Horsens is a town on the east coast of the Jutland region of Denmark. The population is about 65,000 and, in recent years, has grown by about 1.7% annually. Formerly known for its large state prison, positioned on a hill in the middle of the town, Horsens' narrative was predominantly negative until strategic experience design initiatives were introduced, radically altering this perception. The state prison was in use until 2006, see Appendix Images 1-3. This legacy cast a long shadow over Horsens, fostering a poor self-image among its inhabitants. Common resident sentiments were feelings of inability to compete with larger towns in terms of innovation and spectacle. Horsens was often

sarcastically referred to as a place you would end up in if you had just been released from prison, highlighting the negative stereotype associated with living in Horsens.

The town's transformation journey began at the turn of the millennium with a bold vision to pivot from a 'Prison Town' to an 'Experience Town.' This rebranding was not merely superficial but involved a comprehensive overhaul of the town's narrative and the experiences it offered. The transition witnessed Horsens evolving from a peripheral town that relied heavily on its old industries to a vibrant, fun, and up-and-coming town. While still honoring its industrial roots, the town also started nurturing new creative industries, signaling a dynamic shift in its economic and cultural landscape. See Appendix Images 4-10.

Research design, data collection, and analysis

We chose an explorative qualitative research design employing primary and secondary data sources. Primary data were collected over a period of four years through a set of interviews (summarized in Table 1) and in-person observations conducted in Horsens by one of the authors. Secondary data were collected from a wide range of sources, including websites, videos, and written materials, and helped triangulate the findings from the primary data.

Table 1: Interviews. Interview informants are referred to using pseudonyms to ensure anonymity.

Pseudonym	Description
A	Local entrepreneur and lifetime resident
B	Local artist
C	Local consulting business owner
D	Lifetime resident, designer
E	Former foreign student at VIA University College in Horsens
F	Recent immigrant to Horsens from abroad
G	Short-term resident (for work) in Horsens from abroad
H	Past member of the Town Council of Horsens

To analyze the data, we followed the Gioia methodology (Gioia et al., 2013), starting with open coding. The initial codes were organized into first-order categories, and these were then analyzed to

identify patterns, resulting in second-order themes. To provide a high-level view of the data, the second-order themes were then aggregated into dimensions. The results of this process are shown in Table 2 at the end of the Findings section.

Findings

In this section, the first-order categories identified in the data are discussed followed by the development of second-order themes and aggregated dimensions.

First-order categories

One simple theme

Following several strategy sessions, the Horsens Town Council rallied around the theme of transforming Horsens "from a Prison Town to an Experience Town". The idea was to acknowledge and respect Horsens' past while actively steering the narrative toward a more positive future. This gave rise to the development of a focused branding strategy based on the theme of Experience Town. However, the results of this strategy did not materialize immediately, in fact 15 years would pass before there was noticeable evidence of success (Wiese, 2013).

> *"Creating a new story takes time. Nothing was going to happen overnight. A lot of time and money was spent before we saw any results." (Interviewee H)*

Honoring shared history

The Horsens prison continues to make up a dominant theme in Horsens' shared history. Rather than attempting to bury, sugar-coat, or otherwise mask this element of the town's history, the establishment and promotion of Horsens' Prison Museum has firmly established the prison as part of Horsens' DNA.

> *"As strange as it might sound – my favorite place is The Prison. Simply because it encapsulates the amazing development that the city of Horsens has gone through. What used to be one of Denmark's state prisons is today an international recognized prison museum, event space, and unique concert venue" (Mayor Peter Sørensen, in a published interview, 2020).*

The prison, operational until 2006, is not just an abstract idea from a distant past; many of the people living in Horsens belong to or are descended from "prison families"—the families of prisoners who moved to Horsens to be close to their loved ones, the families of prison employees, or the families of past prisoners.

> *"We've always known Horsens for its prison, but now it's a place where history meets innovation. It's not about forgetting the past, but about embracing it to create a better future." (Interviewee A)*

In addition to honoring shared history, the residents of Horsens exhibit a strong sense of their national identity as Danes.

Population buy-in

One needs to spend only a day or two in Horsens talking with the locals to understand that the residents "walk the talk".

> *"Every one of us is a part of Horsens' story. It's not just the buildings or the streets that make our town; it's the people and their dreams," (Interviewee D).*

Any conversation about Horsens invariably touches upon what the residents describe as the *"stroke of genius"* (Interviewee A) that was the branding of Horsens as an Experience Town. This is not viewed as a mere tagline but rather a promise made to the town, *"a commitment that resonates with every billboard and every event staged in Horsens"* (Interviewee C). Conversations with locals suggest a strong openness to change and eagerness to realize the full potential of Horsens as an Experience Town.

> *"Living in Horsens we witness change firsthand. The journey from our prison legacy to becoming an experience hub has turned every local into both a participant and storyteller of the transformation." (Interviewee B)*

A former student at the local university college (interviewee E), who spent a few years living in Horsens, was keenly aware of *"seeing the town embrace change."*

Converging around a shared passion

Football (soccer) is arguably the most popular sport in Denmark, and indeed, a football stadium was built in Horsens in 1929. As part of Horsens' reinvention, the stadium was renovated in 2009. This was a significant project aimed at branding the stadium as a central hub for not just football but also major cultural events. The goal was for the stadium to become a brand itself, reflecting the intensity and excitement of football while ensuring the safety and comfort of players and spectators. Four large floodlight pylons were designed not only to embody efficient technology but also to serve as landmarks for Horsens. These pylons were expected to become a symbol of the town, especially when they glowed in the dark during stadium events, enhancing the visual appeal and brand image of the stadium. The stadium, now known as Nordstern Arena Horsens, has become a popular speedway and concert venue and is a great source of pride for residents.

Sports have the capacity to bring people together around a shared passion:

> *"Football isn't just a game in Horsens; it's a community event that brings us all together. It's a celebration of our town's spirit," (Interviewee D)*

The decision to invest heavily in elevating Horsens' stadium from "just" a football stadium to an impressive landmark equal to hosting top football teams and entertainers such as The Rolling Stones and Madonna appears to have been an effective means to instill pride and a sense of belonging among residents.

Engaged politicians

When asked what the secret to Horsens' revitalization was, Interviewee A stated firmly that *"it's all about the politicians."*

> *"Our leaders didn't just make plans; they painted visions. Visions of a vibrant, thriving Horsens that we all wanted to be a part of," (Interviewee C)*

A great deal of the success of Horsens has been attributed to the former mayor of Horsens, Jan Trøjborg, who died in 2012 while riding a bicycle in a race. This happened the day before a Giro d'Italia stage took place in Horsens; Trøjborg had been instrumental in bringing the 2012 Giro to Denmark. Thus, Trøjborg became a symbol of fervent devotion to Horsens. Effective leadership can

galvanize action, including volunteerism, and indeed a large part of Horsens' success can be attributed to engagement by and with volunteers.

> *"The targeted effort to change the city's image has been a process over a couple of decades created in close cooperation between the City Council, business, institutions and volunteer zealots," (Henning Nørbæk, Horsens' Head of Culture, in a presentation in 2013).*

Clear vision

The Horsens' Town Council developed a clear vision of what Horsens would become. Rather than forging a narrative about making things "better" through incremental improvements, the vision was for a full transformation to becoming an Experience Town.

> *"Our commitment to transforming Horsens was based on a vision that extended beyond short-term gains. It was about changing perceptions, both among our residents and externally to the wider world." (Interviewee H)*

One of the many tangible manifestations of this commitment was the erection of "Kuben" (the cube), a 6x6x6 meter transparent cube in the middle of Horsens' Main Street (Søndergade). The cube, available to anyone who wants to use it, serves as a venue for a variety of cultural experiences, such as concerts, theater performances, rehearsals, and exhibitions. In line with the Experience Town vision, the idea is that people—locals or visitors, shoppers or strollers—will experience something memorable.

> *"It's incredible to see how our industrial town has transformed into a hub for creativity and innovation. It's a testament to Horsens' adaptability and forward-thinking approach." (Interviewee B).*

New (creative) industries alongside old industries

While Horsens continued to support its traditional industries, it also embraced new, creative industries, signifying a balanced approach to economic development. Lying at the end of Horsens Fjord in eastern Jutland, Horsens has long had a strategic harbor, serving predominantly cargo ships. Several proposals for how to revitalize the harbor area—without compromising its functional

operations—were evaluated with the goal of creating conditions for creativity to flourish. To this end a new port canal and promenade were developed with ample public spaces for recreation.

In the last decade, Horsens has attracted a large number of creative sector businesses and artists and is becoming known for a vibrant business community consisting of both technology-based firms and design firms.

> *"It's incredible to see how our industrial town has transformed into a hub for creativity and innovation. It's a testament to adaptability and forward-thinking" (Interviewee C).*
>
> *"The shift towards an Experience Town has opened new opportunities for businesses like mine. But it's not just about economic growth but about being part of a community that's rewriting its story." (Interviewee A)*

Welcoming to new residents

In the Horsens prisons' heyday, people mostly moved to Horsens under dark auspices, such as to be close to an incarcerated loved one. This resulted in a prevailing pall of the undesirability of moving to Horsens among Danes. In the 1970s, a Danish physician was offered an attractive position in Horsens but had to turn it down because his teenage children refused to move to Horsens due to its grim reputation *(personal communication)*.

The Town Council realized that for Horsens to flourish and reach its full potential as an Experience Town, it would need to attract new residents. However, this was a classic chicken-and-egg problem because to flourish, Horsens needed to attract residents but to attract residents, it needed to flourish.

> *"The story of Horsens is the story of transformation. Horsens used to be a city struggling with a bad reputation. Today everything has changed, and the city of Horsens is on everyone's lips as a city of culture and a city of growth. The population is growing steadily, our citizens are educating themselves even better than before, and the average lifespan is increasing" (Mayor Peter Sørensen, in a published interview).*

Unlike towns and regions that put effort into attracting tourists, Horsens' focus was and is on attracting people to move and relocate to Horsens. Interviews with a recent immigrant revealed

impressions of a very welcoming attitude largely free of the bureaucratic red tape and shuffle that often plagues immigrants. Interviewee F talked about a welcoming community and how easy it had been for her child to be assimilated into elementary school despite a language barrier. A shorter-term resident (Interviewee G), who had moved to Horsens for one year for work, was similarly positively impressed with how easy it was to move to Horsens, rent an apartment, and get on with what she came to do.

Second-order themes and aggregate dimensions

The next step in the analysis was to identify second-order themes followed by aggregating these into dimensions of designing place. Below, we discuss each of the aggregate dimensions and the second-order themes that make them up, thereby offering a framework for understanding the dimensions of designing place.

Co-creation

The first aggregate dimension of designing place is co-creation or collaboration. This dimension permeates the case of Horsens. Although the crucial role of leadership is evident in the case, this role is one of galvanizing a collaborative approach involving policymakers, businesses, and, last but not least, the population. There is a clear focus on the active involvement and endorsement of Horsens' residents in the transformation process, reflecting the second-order theme of civic engagement.

We see the incorporation of new industries in shaping the future and the active involvement and endorsement of the town's residents in the transformation process, reflecting the second-order theme of collaborative transformation.

Accounts of successful initiatives—ranging from the reinvention of the prison as a museum to the revitalization of the harbor area—demonstrate how co-creation transcended traditional participatory approaches, embedding itself into the fabric of Horsens' transformation. This dimension underscores the significance of multi-stakeholder engagement in fostering a shared vision for the future, aligning closely with the second-order themes of civic engagement and collaborative transformation.

Inclusion and inclusiveness

The second aggregate dimension of designing place is inclusion and inclusiveness, manifesting in the town's welcoming attitude towards newcomers. There was evidence of the active involvement of the community in integrating and supporting new residents (second-order theme), reinforcing the strength and cohesion of the community fabric. Horsens did not set out to attract tourists, unlike what is quite common among towns and regions around the world; instead, Horsens set out to attract new residents—new blood to revitalize the community.

Omni-temporal narrative

The third aggregated dimension of designing place is story or narrative, more specifically omni-temporal narrative, which recognizes the conscious effort to honor and incorporate Horsens' past, particularly the prison's history—reflecting the second-order theme of embracing heritage—into the town's evolving narrative of a vibrant future. The Town Council crafted a simple and cohesive narrative around becoming an Experience Town, showcasing a clear and patient marketing strategy that aligns with Horsens' vision for the future. This reflects the second-order theme of strategic branding and vision. Also evident is the sense of shared identity and pride among Horsens' residents, fostered through shared passions and cultural initiatives. The transformation of Horsens is something of a cultural renaissance. Events, spaces, and the arts tell a new story of the town, engaging residents and visitors in a narrative of renewal and possibility.

Table 2: Data structure.

First-order concepts	Second-order themes	Aggregate dimensions
Engaged politicians	Collaborative transformation	Co-creation
New (creative) industries alongside old industries		
Population buy-in	Civic engagement	
Welcoming to new residents	Integration and support	Inclusion/Inclusiveness
Honoring shared history	Embracing Heritage	Omni-temporal narrative
Converging around a shared passion	Shared identity and pride	
Clear vision	Strategic Branding and Vision	
One simple theme		

Discussion

The transformation of the town of Horsens in Denmark over the last two decades illustrates the processes and impact of *designing place* in the context of a peripheral town. Our analysis of the case of Horsens enables us to identify core dimensions of designing place: co-creation, omni-temporal narrative, and inclusion/inclusiveness. By attending to these dimensions, we maintain that peripheral towns can reimagine themselves through narratives and thereby improve the lives of residents and attract new residents.

Co-creation as a catalyst for transforming a peripheral town

The transformation of Horsens has been enabled by a variety of stakeholders working together both top-down and bottom-up. Our findings build on the "periphery-as-process" (Coenen, 2023) perspective, which highlights the ways in which peripheral towns create their own narratives and agency for transformation, which is distinctive from those of large urban areas. Through collective

experiences and coordinated design, Horsens has pursued a place branding strategy of honoring, and even exploiting its prison's grim legacy. This resonates with Scranton's embracing of their sad "declining rustbelt" legacy in the US (Rich, 2013). Horsens' experience also resonates with the study of peripheral towns in Norway and Sweden by Coenen (2023, p.58): "Care for place is enacted by mobilizing both individual and social creativity through inclusive practices and collective action." In all these cases, inclusion and community engagement seem to be the key.

Our findings illustrate that co-creation served as a pivotal mechanism in Horsens' transformation, aligning with Vargo and Lusch's (2004) service-dominant logic, which posits value creation as a collaborative and ongoing process. This approach, emphasizing stakeholder engagement across levels, from local governments to residents, underscores the potential for co-creation to galvanize community support, foster innovation, and drive meaningful change in urban settings. It challenges traditional, top-down models of urban planning, advocating for a more participatory and inclusive approach to designing place.

Inclusiveness as a foundation for long-term development

The emphasis on inclusiveness in Horsens' strategy highlights the importance of creating welcoming and supportive environments for all residents, including newcomers. This approach aligns with recent calls within the urban studies literature for more inclusive urban development strategies. In much of the literature on regional development, innovation-dense "creative cities" (Florida, 2002) have attracted attention. In his book *The New Urban Crisis* (2017) Richard Florida auto-critiqued and recanted his earlier "creative class" thesis in view of urban inequality and social segregation. This also reflects a growing recognition of the need to design urban spaces and policies that facilitate integration, support social cohesion, and promote equity, and recognize diversity as a strength.

Omni-temporal narrative construction weaving the past, present, and future

The town of Horsens has shaped a narrative of a place encompassing the past, present, and future. Such collaborative approaches to "omni-temporality" (Reynolds et al., 2024) and "meaning making of a place" (Coenen, 2023) may take a long time to come to fruition. Raymond and colleagues (2017,

p.1) argue that place attachments and place meanings are slow to evolve, sometimes "not matching material or social reality (lag effects)", which may inhibit change. They raise a question regarding how processes of "perception–action and social construction" could be included in the "design and management of urban landscapes".

The omni-temporal approach to narrative construction in Horsens highlights the power of storytelling in urban regeneration. By embracing its history while actively crafting a forward-looking identity, Horsens demonstrates how narrative strategies can influence perception, belonging, and community pride. This finding resonates with the work of Raymond et al. (2017), suggesting that place attachments and meanings evolve through complex interplays of history, present action, and future aspirations. This raises important considerations for how urban planners and policymakers can harness narrative construction to support identity formation and community cohesion.

Implications for urban development of peripheral towns

The case of Horsens contributes to a nuanced understanding of designing place, suggesting that peripheral towns can leverage their unique narratives and community assets to foster regeneration and growth. It underscores the importance of adaptive, inclusive, and narrative-driven strategies in contemporary urban development. For policymakers and urban designers, the Horsens case offers valuable insights into the potential of using designing place, a special case of experience design, to catalyze economic revitalization, enhance community well-being, and reposition urban centers on the periphery.

Directions for future research

While this study provides important insights into the process and impact of designing place in Horsens, it also opens avenues for further investigation. Future research could explore the long-term sustainability of Horsens' transformation, examining how initial successes in designing place evolve over time and impact residents' quality of life. Additionally, comparative studies of other peripheral towns undergoing similar transformations could offer broader perspectives on the replicability of the Horsens model and its adaptability to different urban contexts.

Conclusion

In this paper, we build on recent design literature to propose that *designing place*, a specific case of experience design, can lead to collective transformation, resonating with the Special Issue's focus on innovative design within a larger ecosystem. Methodologically, we advocate a qualitative, bottom-up-driven, slow, contextualized, and deep-data-oriented approach.

We illustrate the concept of designing place in the context of a peripheral town where mimicking strategies relevant in urban cores would not have worked. The findings shed light on the power of "spatial imaginaries" (Watkins, 2015) of a peripheral town by employing a design lens. In designing place, individual agency becomes collective transformation, which resonates with Gilmore and Pine's (2007) proposal that transformation represents the highest stage in the progression of economic value, preceded by commodities, goods, services, and experiences.

We contribute to design literature by arguing that designing place is a manifestation of experience design, where a place's narrative and identity are transformed through multi-modal, co-creative, and emotionally engaging strategies. It provides a holistic and inclusive approach that not only redefines the physical and social landscape of a peripheral town but also elevates the experience of living, working, and visiting such a place, thereby contributing to residents' sense of pride, revitalization, and long-term growth. Our proposition is that transforming peripheral towns calls for essentially designing comprehensive experiences that offer differentiation, emotional connections, and a sense of belonging.

This study contributes a critical and reflective perspective to urban and regional development literature calling for more holistic, relational, and inclusive approaches to urban and town planning and place-based responses to historical legacies by highlighting the transformation of a peripheral town. In much of the literature on regional development, innovation-dense "creative cities" (Florida, 2002) have attracted attention. In his book 'The New Urban Crisis' (2017) Richard Florida auto-critiqued and recanted his earlier "creative class" thesis in view of urban inequality and social

segregation. A more inclusive place-based policy approach to peripheral towns may help solve some of the challenges faced by a variety of types of left-behind places.

The findings of our research carry several implications for practitioners and policy-makers responsible for place branding and development by providing potential pathways to "de-peripheralize" left-behind places. We propose that the elements of designing place provide a solid starting-point for place-based design, planning, and policy formation, which can lead to new policy positions encompassing new forms of alliance between citizens, local communities, policymakers, and governance structures.

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Appendix – Images







Images 1-3: The grim legacy of Horsens State Prison.





Images 4-5: Prison cells transformed into creative spaces.



Image 6: National pride.

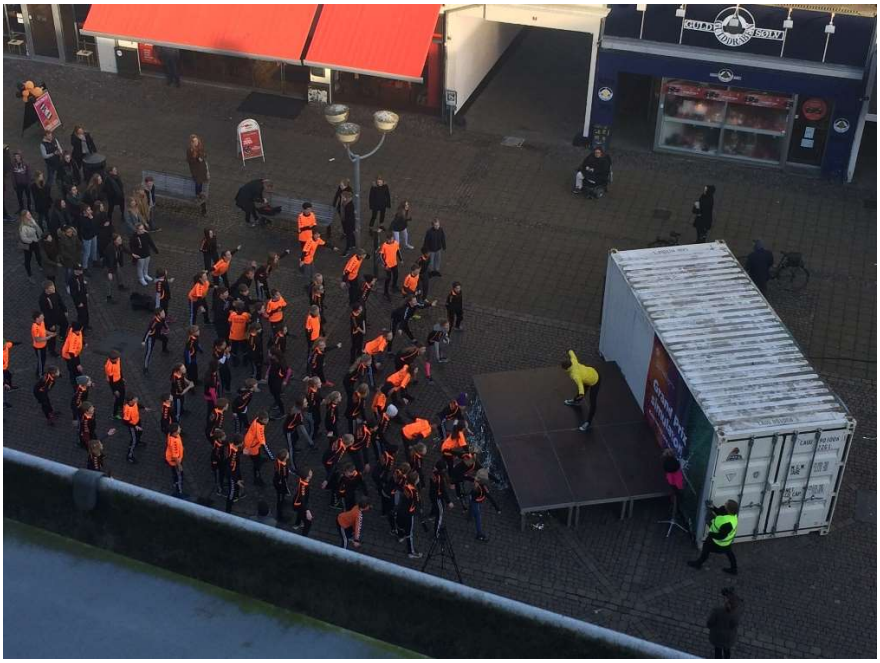
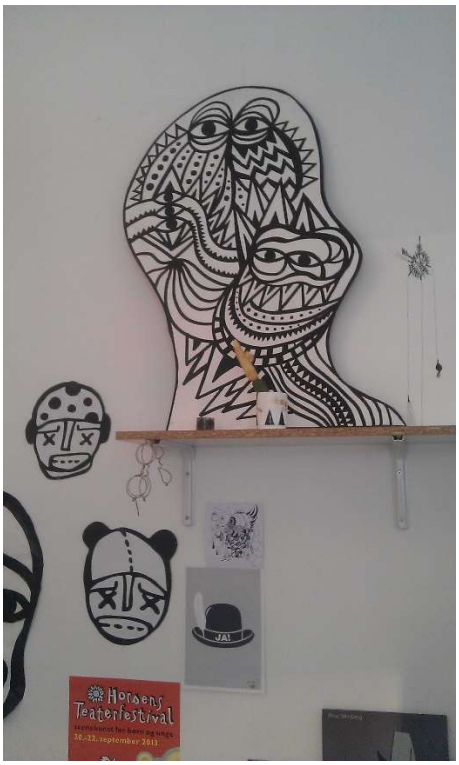


Image 7: Motivation to move on Horsens Main Street.







Images 8-10: Faces of the new Horsens.

Art credits: Image 8: Phuc Van Dang; Image 9: Michael Kvium; Image 10: Thomas Dambo.

Photo credits: All photos were taken by the authors. Persons' faces have been obscured in the interest of privacy.